

Lesson: Composition

Composition

The Visual Elements

A composition, like a painting, includes lines, shapes, values, colors, and textures to create the composition on the canvas. A photograph is composed of these things as well. How we view the world through our own eyes also creates the composition of what we see and how we see it. Other elements like overlap, patterns, positive and negative space, contrast and similarity, framing, and movement are also used.

Lines

The most basic element of design is the line. Lines can be used to create certain meanings within a composition. They can mean calmness, strength, or imbalance depending on their angle. They can be used to lead the eye through a composition, like an arrow pointing the way down a path. Or they can divide a space.

Vertical lines appear powerful. In this shot of Wall Street, for example, the vertical lines of the large financial buildings imply a sense of strength, stability, or power.



Horizontal lines imply stability, quietness, or restfulness. The still waters in this picture create a horizontal line that implies a calm, easy feeling.



Diagonal lines invoke motion within a shot and can be used to lead the eye through a composition. They might also suggest action, violence, or energy.

In this example, the lines of the road lead the viewers eye down the path.



Curved Lines

Curved lines can have different meanings depending on their shape. Sharp curves, such as ocean waves, suggest turbulence. Soft curves, like the rolling hills in the picture above, imply a sensual or soothing quality and can suggest harmony.

Jagged Lines

Lines that are jagged convey a sense of restlessness and aggressiveness. A bolt of lightning is an example of the most basic jagged line.

In this shot from *The Lord of the Rings*, the absence of any visible lines is, itself, uneasy. You could say that the lines where the land meets the waters, the bare trees, and the tips of the clumps of grass are jagged. Either way, this is not a very inviting place and it is composed to show that. However, you can notice a diagonal strip of land that they are walking on, leading them in the direction they need to go.



Shapes and Forms

Shapes

When discussing shapes within a composition we're not referring to actual solid shapes but, instead, the shapes of the composed image that can include triangular, circular, and arch.

Triangle



Circular or Arch



Values

Values create positive and negative spaces within a composition. They can also add depth as in the examples below.



Colors

Colors are used to invoke certain feelings or to draw attention to a certain point. In this example from *Inside Out*, colors are used to show the personality of each character. Fear is purple, Anger is red, Joy is yellow, Disgust is green, and Sadness is blue.



Overlap

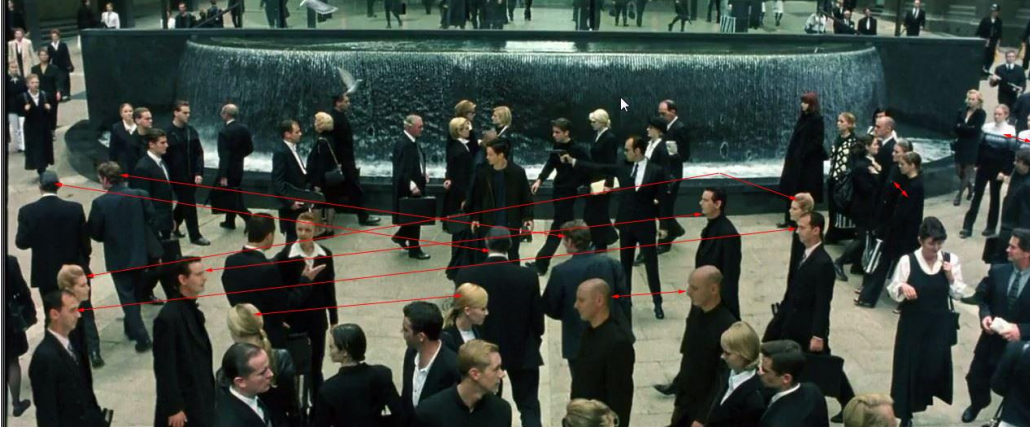
Overlapping objects creates a more pleasing composition. It creates movement within a shot that would otherwise be flat and two dimensional.



Contrast & Similarity

Our eyes are drawn to these. When we see things that are similar in appearance or are very different then we tend to pick up on these things very quickly. This scene from *The Matrix* is an excellent

example of both. We notice the similarity in everyone because of their plain, boring black suits, white shirts, and black ties. To go a step further, the Wachowski's cast twins for this scene so everyone who isn't Neo, Morpheus, Agent Smith, or the woman in the red dress is a twin. They wanted to instill in the viewer a sense of déjà vu but without it being obvious. They wanted you to watch this scene and then go; "Hey, I just saw that same person in another shot." So if you did and thought it was just bad editing, think again.



On the other hand, the contrast is instantly recognizable with the woman in the red dress. When she came on screen you probably noticed more details about her than you did of anyone in a black suit.



Patterns

Patterns offer the same as similarity in that it attracts the eye, sometimes leading it through a scene. In this example from *Full Metal Jacket* the soldiers are the pattern, repeating one after the other down

the barracks.



Positive & Negative Space

Positive space is the space filled by the subject within a shot while the space around it is considered negative space. In an interesting juxtaposition, in this shot from *Star Wars: The Force Awakens* the positive space is filled with the sun and clouds and sky while the negative space is the Tie Fighters silhouetted against the sun.



Framing, Movement, and Meaning

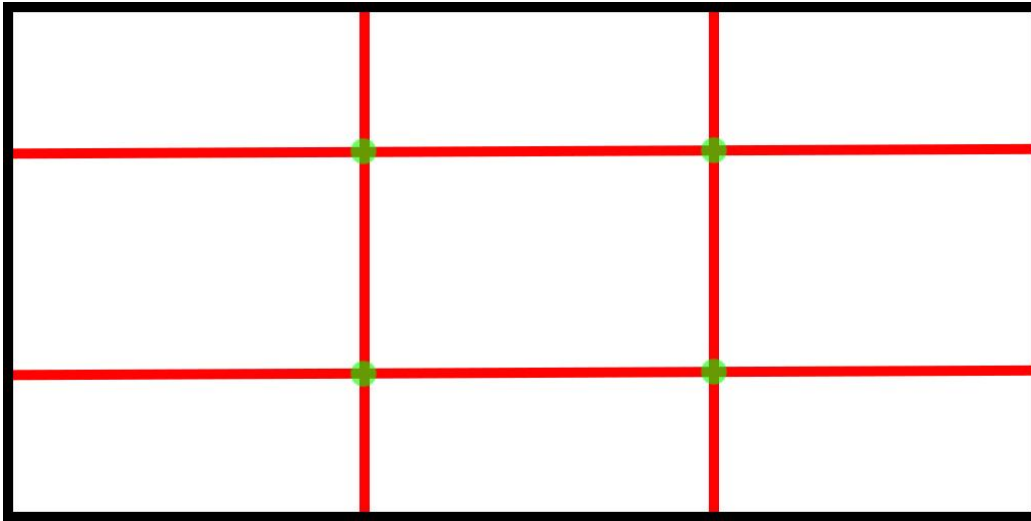
Unlike a typical frame, the border of the film frame is part of the shot. It can be used to not only create the illusion of movement within the frame by the placement of characters and objects, but also meaning.

Characters can enter or exit a frame from the left or right, top or bottom. It is more natural when the placement of characters or objects leads the eye from left to right, like reading a book. A well-framed shot takes into consideration not only what is in the frame but what is excluded from it. Only showing

someone's feet as they walk down a dark corridor, for instance, creates suspense. Framing an object toward one of the four corners of the frame creates tension, which produces a visually stimulating image. Objects that are framed in the center lack the same compositional weight as objects nearer to one of the corners.

Rule of Thirds

The rule of thirds suggests that you divide the frame into three sections both vertically and horizontally, placing the focal points where the lines cross.



In this example from *The Good, The Bad, and The Ugly*, it may seem as though each character is centered in the shot. Technically they are, but what is being composed in the shot is their eyes, with each of them at or near the two focal points in the top third.



Open and Closed Frame

Open frames leave space that allow the subject to move freely in or out of the frame. In this scene from *North by Northwest* the frame is left wide open to express a sense of desperation for the character being chased by the plane. He is free to move in any direction to escape.



Closed frames create space that restricts movement within the frame. In this example from *Training Day* the character is framed by the arms, the table, and the clutter on the table evoking a sense of being confined or trapped.



Head Room and Look Space

Head room refers to the amount of space between the top of the head and the top of the frame. Too much head room and it makes the visual seem desperate, in despair, or lonely. Too little and it's confining and claustrophobic.

Look space, or lead room, refers to the space that is in front of the character to the edge of the frame. Typically this should be about two-thirds of the frame. In this shot from *Star Wars - A New Hope*, Luke is seen looking at the suns setting over the horizon on his planet of Tatooine. In the example on the left he is being cut off by the top and right side of the frame. This is poor framing. There is plenty of room within the frame to compose a more visually appealing shot such as in the example on the right.



Types of Balance: Symmetrical vs Asymmetrical

Symmetrical Balance creates a frame that is even in visual weight while asymmetrical balance creates a frame that is uneven. In this example from the movie *Office Space* the shot on the left is asymmetrical while the shot on the right is symmetrical.



The shot on the left has one character occupying the left side while two others occupy the right side. This creates more visual weight on the right side of the frame. On the other hand, it could be considered that the character on the left possesses more visual weight due to us seeing more of him and less of the other two characters. The context of this scene is also meant to establish his confidence so making him appear visually more heavy reinforces this. The shot on the right is symmetrically balanced. The two characters facing us are set on either side of the frame with a third character dividing the frame in the middle. This creates an evenly distributed visual weight.